

A patient who has been diagnosed with schizophrenia is prescribed a neuroleptic medication. Which of the following symptoms, if present, is this medication most likely to improve?

- ☐ A. Apathy [8%]
☐ B. Inability to experience pleasure [9%]
☐ C. Emotional flattening [24%]
☒ D. Disorganized speech [57%]

Correct

58% answered correctly

Explanation:

Schizophrenia symptoms	
Positive ("pathological excesses")	Negative ("pathological deficits")
• Hallucinations: False sensory perception (eg, hearing voices) in the absence of stimuli • Delusions: False belief (eg, "the neighbors are aliens") despite evidence to the contrary • Disorganized/incoherent speech • Disorganized/agitated behavior	• Apathy: A lack of motivation • Social withdrawal • Flat affect: Emotional flattening/monotone speech • Poverty (lack) of speech • Anhedonia: Inability to experience pleasure

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Psychotic disorders are severe psychological disorders characterized by a loss of contact with reality. Schizophrenia is the most common psychotic disorder, with a prevalence of about 1% in the United States.

Schizophrenia typically involves both **positive symptoms**, which are "pathological excesses" (eg, hallucinations, delusions, disorganized speech), and **negative symptoms**, which are "pathological deficits" (eg, apathy, inability to experience pleasure). Many people with schizophrenia also experience psychomotor symptoms (ie, changes in muscle tone or activity), which can occur either as a symptom of schizophrenia or as a side effect of medication.

Schizophrenia is often treated with **neuroleptic** (conventional, typical, or first-generation) or **atypical** (second-generation) **antipsychotic** medication; both are generally effective in reducing positive symptoms. However, neuroleptics may exacerbate (worsen) negative symptoms through sedation or cognitive dulling, and they carry the risk of movement (eg, tremors) and other side effects. Atypical antipsychotics pose less risk of many of these side effects and in some cases may improve negative symptoms.

A neuroleptic medication would be most likely to effectively treat (improve) disorganized speech, which is a *positive symptom* of schizophrenia.

(Choices A, B, and C) Apathy, inability to experience pleasure, and emotional flattening are all negative symptoms of schizophrenia. Neuroleptic medications are

generally not effective in treating negative symptoms, and the side effects may even exacerbate them.

Educational objective:

Schizophrenia is a psychotic disorder characterized by positive symptoms (ie, hallucinations, delusions, disorganized speech) and negative symptoms (eg, apathy, emotional flattening). Schizophrenia is often treated with either neuroleptic or atypical antipsychotics; both are generally effective in reducing positive symptoms, but neuroleptics have a greater risk of side effects (eg, sedation, psychomotor disturbances).

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Behavioral Sciences

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System:
Sensation, Perception, and Consciousness